RE: A question on the difficulty of Russell Group courses in STEM subjects

2 messages

CEO Office <CEO.Office@russellgroup.ac.uk> 23 April 2024 at 08:47
To: Aruna Nagesha <ArunaThePuppyLoverInIndia1234@outlook.com>

Dear Aruna,

Russell Group universities are autonomous institutions that work to ensure high academic standards. The courses delivered by Russell Group universities are intellectually demanding which is reflected in the high tariff requirement for admissions and the successes of our graduates and alumni. For more information about quality and standards please refer to the QAA: https://www.qaa.ac.uk/membership/membership-areas-of-work/quality-and-standards.

Many thanks,

Debbie

Debbie Halpenny

Executive PA to Dr Tim Bradshaw, Chief Executive

The Russell Group

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www.russellgroup.ac.uk

The Russell Group represents 24 leading UK universities. We believe people and ideas are the key to meeting global challenges. Through world-class research and education we are helping to create a dynamic economy, stronger communities and a better future for the UK.

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From: Aruna Nagesha <ArunaThePuppyLoverInIndia1234@outlook.com>
Sent: Monday, April 22, 2024 10:40 PM
To: CEO Office <CEO.Office@russellgroup.ac.uk>
Subject: A question on the difficulty of Russell Group courses in STEM subjects

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Hello

I am Aruna and called you recently. My question is below

I have been reading around Russell Group universities on your website and have read through many of your publications. One key thing that stands out to me is the statement that:

"Russell Group courses are designed to be intellectually challenging and decisions as to who can enter these courses are based on academic evaluation of whether candidates would be able to meet the demands of that course"

This implies that university courses do differ in degree difficulty substantially, between different universities.

I spoke to the Business manager at my university, Robert, and he told me that all university courses are equivalent in academic demand. Russell group university courses are "not designed to be intellectually demanding".

This does pose some questions in my mind, as it conflicts with the statement above in quotation marks (from an article from 2018)

There is also the question of why high tariff institutions pose more problems for lower ability applicants.

For instance, 76% of students who go to high tariff institutions with AAB or better at a level gain a 2:1 or better. But only 46% of students with BBC/BCC at A Level who are at high tariff institutions do so.

This implicitly implies that higher tariff Institutions pose more academically challenging and demanding courses compared to those of lower tariffinstitutions.

Furthermore, there are also differences between the quality of STEM graduates between different universities. The best, most able graduates tend to be from Russell Group universities. On your website I can infer that Russell Group universities offer the most intellectually challenging courses designed for high ability students.

If all courses at all universities across the whole country in STEM subjects were exactly the same in difficulty from an academic perspective, then there would be minimal difficulty in recruiting graduates, as the vast majority of STEM graduates would be of equal calibre.

Really hope to receive a reply in due course and hear your thoughts

Regards,

Aruna

Aruna Nagesha <ArunaThePuppyLoverInIndia1234@outlook.com> 23 April 2024 at 08:47
To: "tompiccolo50@gmail.com" <tompiccolo50@gmail.com>

From: CEO Office <CEO.Office@russellgroup.ac.uk>
Sent: 23 April 2024 09:47:20 (UTC+00:00) Dublin, Edinburgh, Lisbon, London
To: Aruna Nagesha <ArunaThePuppyLoverInIndia1234@outlook.com>
Subject: RE: A question on the difficulty of Russell Group courses in STEM subjects
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